

Index of Services Production



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) is set to launch the **Index of Services Production (ISP)** in **July 2026** . This initiative creates a new macro-indicator to track the growth of India's services sector, acting as a counterpart to the existing **Index of Industrial Production (IIP)** .

- Developed by a **Technical Advisory Committee (TAC)** chaired by **Debjani Ghosh** , the ISP will initially be released on a **trial basis** with sectoral indices.

What are the Key Facts About the Index of Services Production (ISP)?

- **About:** The **Index of Services Production (ISP)** is a **monthly high-frequency macroeconomic indicator** developed by the **Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI)** to measure **short-term changes in the real output of India's formal services sector** , similar to the **Index of Industrial Production (IIP)** for industry.
- **Need:** Services contribute **over 50% of India's Gross Value Added** since 2013-14, but there's been no monthly, high-frequency indicator tracking how that sector is actually growing in real (inflation-adjusted) terms.
- **Objective:** It provides timely information on **services sector growth** , strengthens economic monitoring, supports **policy formulation** , improves **economic forecasting** , and complements the IIP in tracking overall economic activity.
- **Improved Data Ecosystem:** The availability of **high-frequency GST data** on outward supplies of service enterprises and the launch of the **Annual Survey of Incorporated Services Sector Enterprises (ASISSE)** have made it possible to compile a reliable **ISP** .

Key Mechanics of ISP

- **Scope and Limitations:** The ISP is restricted to the **formal sector** and excludes non-market government activities, personal services, and the **informal sector** .
- **Excluded areas:** Public administration & defence, gambling, personal services, government-run health/education, and a few other non-market activities

- **Methodological Framework:** The ISP is compiled using a **fixed-weight Laspeyres volume index** with **2024-25 as the base year** (aligned with the rebased **CPI series**), and assigns **Gross Value Added (GVA)- based weights** to reflect the relative economic importance of each services sector.
 - It tracks the volume of output, transforming **nominal turnover data into real growth measures** using **deflators like CPI (Consumer Price Index) and WPI (Wholesale Price Index)**.
- **Major Data Sources for ISP:**
 - **Administrative/Secondary Data:** Used for **Air Transport, Railways, Banking, and Insurance** .
 - **GST Data:** Covers sectors such as **trade, transport, telecommunications, accommodation, real estate, professional services, and arts & recreation** through outward supplies.
 - **ASISSE Data:** Used for **Health and Education (excluding government)** services.
- **Quantity vs Value Indicators:** **Air Transport** and **Railways** are measured using **quantity-based indicators** (e.g., passenger-kilometres), while most other services use **value-based indicators** such as **turnover, sales, or GST outward supplies** .
- **Preferred Output Measure:** The preferred indicator is **turnover adjusted (deflated) by an appropriate price index** , as services are consumed immediately after production and turnover closely reflects output.
- **Deflators Used:** ISP uses **WPI** for wholesale trade, **sector-specific CPI** where available, **CPI General** for banking and insurance, and **CPI Non-Food** for other services.
 - A **deflator** removes the effect of price changes from nominal service revenues to measure the **real growth** in service output.
- **Trial Phase:** MoSPI will release **experimental/trial indices** for 2025-26 and April 2026 starting July 2026, to ensure stability before transitioning to regular, monthly dissemination with a **60-day lag** .
- **Deflator Strategy:** In the absence of comprehensive **Service Producer Price Indices (SPPI)**, MoSPI will use **CPI (Non-Food)** as a proxy deflator.
 - This is justified by the fact that over 80% of non-food inflation is directly linked to services or their cost-push factors, such as energy, transport, and housing.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Index of Services Production (ISP)?

The **Index of Services Production (ISP)** is a **monthly high-frequency indicator** developed by **MoSPI** to measure short-term changes in the **real output of India's formal services sector**, complementing the **Index of Industrial Production (IIP)**.

2. Why has India introduced the Index of Services Production (ISP)?

The services sector contributes **over 50% of India's Gross Value Added (GVA)**, but India lacked a monthly indicator to track its real growth. The ISP fills this gap and strengthens economic monitoring and policymaking.

3. What are the major data sources used for compiling the ISP?

The ISP uses **administrative data**, **GST outward supplies mapped through Service Accounting Codes (SACs) to National Industrial Classification (NIC) codes**, and the **Annual Survey of Incorporated Services Sector Enterprises (ASISSE)**.

4. Why does the ISP use the Consumer Price Index (CPI) instead of the Service Producer Price Index (SPPI)?

Since **SPPIs** are available for only a few service sectors and are released quarterly with a time lag, the ISP primarily uses **CPI (including CPI Non-Food)** as the practical deflator for measuring real service output.

5. What is the methodology used to compile the Index of Services Production (ISP)?

The ISP is compiled using a **fixed-weight Laspeyres volume index** with **2024-25 as the base year**, assigning **GVA-based weights** and converting nominal service turnover into real output using appropriate price deflators.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/tkiQG-dP1GQ](https://www.youtube.com/embed/tkiQG-dP1GQ)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. With reference to India, consider the following statements: (2010)

1. The Wholesale Price Index (WPI) in India is available on a monthly basis only.
2. As compared to Consumer Price Index for Industrial Workers (CPI(IW)), the WPI gives less weight to food articles.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (b)

Q. Consider the following statements: (2020)

1. The weightage of food in Consumer Price Index (CPI) is higher than that in Wholesale Price Index (WPI).
2. The WPI does not capture changes in the prices of services, which CPI does.
3. The Reserve Bank of India has now adopted WPI as its key measure of inflation and to decide on

changing the key policy rates.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (a)

Q. With reference to Indian economy, consider the following statements: (2015)

1. The rate of growth of Real Gross Domestic Product has steadily increased in the last decade.
2. The Gross Domestic Product at market prices (in rupees) has steadily increased in the last decade.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (b)

Q. A decrease in tax to GDP ratio of a country indicates which of the following? (2015)

1. Slowing economic growth rate
2. Less equitable distribution of national income

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q1. Define potential GDP and explain its determinants. What are the factors that have been inhibiting India from realizing its potential GDP? **(2020)**

Q2. Explain the difference between computing methodology of India's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) before the year 2015 and after the year 2015. **(2021)**



For Prelims: Representation of the People Act, 1951 , Fundamental Rights , Election Commission of India

For Mains: Criminalisation of Politics in India: Causes, Consequences and Reforms, Constitutional Morality and Democratic Governance.

Source: TH

Why in News?

A report by the **Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR)** and **National Election Watch (NEW)** has revealed that **31% of sitting Rajya Sabha MPs have declared criminal cases** , while **16% face serious criminal charges** , bringing the critical issue of the **criminalisation of politics** back into the national spotlight.

Summary

- The ADR report showing that 31% of Rajya Sabha MPs face criminal cases has renewed concerns over the criminalisation of politics, highlighting the influence of money, muscle power, and systemic electoral loopholes on India's democracy.
- The issue underscores the need for comprehensive electoral reforms, including stricter disqualification norms, faster trials, greater political transparency, and enhanced voter awareness to uphold constitutional morality and the rule of law.

What are the Key Findings of the ADR Report?

- **Prevalence of Criminal Cases:** Out of the 226 sitting Rajya Sabha MPs analyzed, 31% have declared pending criminal cases against themselves.
 - 16% face serious criminal charges, which include cases related to murder, attempt to murder, kidnapping, and crimes against women.
 - The data indicate that the fielding of candidates with criminal backgrounds is a **systemic issue spanning almost all major national and regional political parties**.
- **State-Wise Concentration:** States such as **Telangana (71%), Delhi (67%), and Maharashtra (53%)** exhibit the highest percentage of MPs with declared criminal cases.
- **Concentration of Wealth:** The report also highlighted extreme wealth concentration in the Upper House. About **14% of the MPs are billionaires** , with the average assets of a Rajya Sabha MP standing at a staggering **Rs 120.69 crore** .
- **Implications for Indian Polity:** The ADR report highlights the entrenched nature of the **criminal-politician-business nexus** , an issue formally recognized three decades ago by the **Vohra Committee (1993)** .

- The entry of individuals with **immense wealth and severe criminal backgrounds** into the **"House of Elders"** has profound implications.
- Lawmakers facing serious criminal charges may influence legislation to serve vested interests or deliberately dilute institutional accountability mechanisms.
- The Rajya Sabha is constitutionally designed to represent state interests and provide expert legislative review. **The dominance of the "winnability" factor, driven by money and muscle, undermines this mandate.**

What is the Criminalisation of Politics?

- **About:** Criminalisation of politics refers to the alarming trend where individuals with **criminal backgrounds, pending charges, or convictions participate in the political and electoral processes of the state**, contesting elections, and holding public office in Parliament and State Legislatures.
 - This phenomenon deeply undermines the **democratic ethos, replacing the rule of law with the rule of money and muscle power**, and compromising the integrity of public institutions.
- **Causes of Increasing Criminalisation:**
 - **The "Winnability" Factor:** Political parties are driven by electoral success. Data reveals that **candidates with criminal records have a significantly higher success rate (approx. 15%)** compared to candidates with clean backgrounds (approx. 4%).
 - Criminals bring their own illicit resources, ensuring they can self-finance campaigns.
 - **Money and Muscle Power:** The **First-Past-The-Post (FPTP) electoral system** and the **exorbitant cost of elections compel** parties to rely on candidates who possess **massive black money reserves and the physical "muscle"** to intimidate rivals, capture booths (historically), and sway voters.
 - **Governance Deficit:** Weak state institutions and poor public service delivery lead many voters to support strongmen with criminal backgrounds, who provide quick, extra-legal solutions by acting as parallel power centres.
 - **Legal Loopholes and Slow Justice:** Under **Section 8 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951**, a person convicted of certain offences and sentenced to **two years or more of imprisonment** is disqualified from contesting elections and remains ineligible for **six years after completing the sentence**.
 - However, the Act does **not disqualify candidates with pending criminal cases**, allowing them to contest elections until they are convicted by a court.
 - Because the **Indian judicial system is slow** (with a backlog of over 5.6 crore pending cases), politicians can spend decades **fighting trials while successfully completing multiple legislative terms**. Mere framing of charges does not bar them from contesting.
 - **Identity Politics and Vote Banks:** Voters frequently prioritize narrow community interests **such as caste, religion, or language** over the criminal antecedents of a candidate.
 - Local strongmen are often perceived as **"Robin Hood" figures** who can cut through bureaucratic red tape to protect and provide for their specific vote banks.
 - **Lack of Inner-Party Democracy:** The opaque nature of ticket distribution within political parties **allows party bosses to bypass grassroots workers in favor of wealthy people who can guarantee a seat**.
- **Ethical Implications of Criminalisation of Politics:** The criminalisation of politics undermines **non-partisanship, accountability, and constitutional morality**, fostering a **culture of impunity** where

electoral success outweighs ethical conduct.

- It weakens **democratic accountability** , erodes public trust, distorts free and fair elections through money and muscle power, and **marginalises women's empowerment** by reducing representation to symbolism rather than genuine empowerment.
- Ultimately, it compromises the **rule of law, transparency, institutional integrity, and inclusive development** , hindering India's democratic and developmental aspirations.

- **Judicial Pronouncements:**

- **Union of India v. Association for Democratic Reforms (2002):** The Supreme Court ruled that voters have a **fundamental right to know** the criminal, financial, and educational background of electoral candidates under **Article 19(1)(a)** , making disclosure through affidavits mandatory.
- **PUCL v. Union of India (2004):** The Supreme Court struck down **Section 33B of the Representation of the People Act, 1951** , reaffirming that voters' **right to know** candidates' antecedents is a fundamental right.
- **K. Prabhakaran v. P. Jayarajan (2005):** The Supreme Court clarified that **Section 8(3) of the Representation of the People Act, 1951** aims to prevent the criminalisation of politics, observing that **"those who break the law should not make the law."**
- **Lily Thomas v. Union of India (2013):** The Supreme Court mandated **immediate disqualification** of MPs and MLAs convicted and sentenced to **two years or more** .
- **Manoj Narula v. Union of India (2014):** The Supreme Court held that while the **Prime Minister has the constitutional discretion** to appoint ministers, persons facing serious criminal charges **should ideally not be included in the Council of Ministers.**
- **Public Interest Foundation v. Union of India (2018):** The Supreme Court ruled that **only Parliament** can enact a law to disqualify candidates upon framing of criminal charges and directed political parties to publicise the criminal antecedents of their candidates.
- **Rambabu Singh Thakur v. Sunil Arora (2020):** The Supreme Court directed the **Election Commission of India** to strictly monitor political parties' compliance with disclosure of candidates' criminal records and report violations to the Court.

What Reforms are Needed to Decriminalise Indian Politics?

- **N.N. Vohra Committee (1993):** Acknowledged the existence of a parallel **government run by mafias and crime syndicates** enjoying political patronage. It recommended setting up a **specialized Nodal Agency under the Ministry of Home Affairs to gather intelligence** and track the financial trails and operational links of criminal-politician-business nexus.
- **Dinesh Goswami Committee (1990) & Indrajit Gupta Committee (1998):** Both committees strongly advocated for partial, **in-kind state funding of elections for recognized political parties.**
 - By providing essential campaign materials (voter slips, fuel, media time) at the state's expense, parties would be less dependent on the "black money" and financial muscle provided by criminal candidates.
- **Second Administrative Reforms Commission (2nd ARC, 2008):** In its report on "Ethics in Governance," the ARC recommended amending Section 8 of the RPA to **immediately disqualify individuals facing trial for serious offenses.**
 - Emphasized the need for a stringent code of ethics for Ministers and legislators to ensure institutional integrity.

- **244th Law Commission Report (2014):** The Commission recommended **disqualifying candidates upon the framing of charges** by a court for offences punishable with **five years or more of imprisonment** , provided the charges are framed **at least one year before scrutiny of nominations** .
- It also proposed **enhanced penalties for filing false electoral affidavits** , with a minimum **two-year imprisonment**, making it a direct ground for disqualification, and recommended **day-to-day trials through dedicated fast-track courts** to ensure the speedy disposal of criminal cases involving politicians.
- **Law Commission (255th Report, 2015):** Recommended strict financial transparency, mandating the disclosure of all political donations regardless of size, and enforcing independent audits of party accounts.
- **Election Commission's Core Proposals:** The Election Commission of India (ECI) has urged the Supreme Court to impose a lifetime ban on convicted politicians from contesting elections instead of the current six-year disqualification after release.
- **Enhancing Voter Awareness:** The Election Commission of India (ECI) and civil society must aggressively educate voters about the backgrounds of their candidates. Widespread awareness, coupled with the **NOTA (None of the Above)** option, can force parties to field cleaner candidates out of electoral necessity.

Relevance of the Nolan Principles in Addressing the Criminalisation of Politics

- **Nolan Principles:** The **Nolan Principles** , also known as the **Seven Principles of Public Life** , were recommended by the **Nolan Committee (Committee on Standards in Public Life)** , established in the **United Kingdom in 1994** under the chairmanship of **Lord Michael Nolan** .
 - They provide an ethical framework to promote **integrity, transparency, accountability, and good governance** among public office holders.
- **Seven Nolan Principles:**
 - **Selflessness:** Public office holders should act solely in the **public interest** .
 - **Integrity:** They should avoid conflicts of interest and not misuse public office for personal gain.
 - **Objectivity:** Decisions should be taken impartially, fairly, and on merit.
 - **Accountability:** Public officials must be answerable for their decisions and actions.
 - **Openness:** Decisions should be transparent, with information shared unless restricted by law.
 - **Honesty:** Public office holders should be truthful and declare any private interests.
 - **Leadership:** Leaders should uphold these principles through their own conduct and promote ethical behaviour in public life.

The Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill, 2025

- The **Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill, 2025** seeks to amend **Articles 75 (Union), 164 (States), and 239AA (Delhi)** to mandate the removal of the Prime Minister, Chief Ministers, or any other Minister if they are arrested and detained in custody for **30 consecutive days** for an offense punishable by imprisonment of **five years or more**.
- The primary objective is to **prevent the anomaly of "governance from jail."** The government argues that allowing individuals facing serious criminal allegations to retain immense executive power **undermines public trust and violates the principles of constitutional morality.**
- **The Arguments Against:**
 - **Erosion of "Presumption of Innocence":** Disqualification is triggered by *arrest and detention* (an executive action) rather than the *framing of charges* or a *conviction* (judicial actions).
 - **Weaponization Risks:** Critics fear that stringent laws with incredibly high thresholds for bail (such as the **PMLA or UAPA**) could be weaponized by ruling dispensations to arbitrarily detain opposition leaders for 30 days, thereby forcing their removal and destabilizing elected state governments.

Conclusion

The criminalisation of politics reflects a **crisis of constitutional morality**, echoing **Dr B.R. Ambedkar's** warning that ***even a good Constitution fails if administered by a "bad lot."*** True reform requires moving beyond reactionary legislation and judicial mandates toward building robust state capacity. Ultimately, the **decriminalisation of politics is not merely about purifying the legislature; it is a fundamental prerequisite for ensuring the rule of law prevails over the rule of muscle.**

Drishti Mains Question:

"Money power and muscle power continue to undermine the integrity of Indian elections." Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is meant by the criminalisation of politics?

It refers to the increasing participation of individuals with criminal backgrounds in elections and legislative bodies, undermining the rule of law and democratic governance.

2. What does Section 8 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951 provide?

It disqualifies legislators upon conviction for specified offences, generally where the sentence is **two years or more** , but not merely upon the framing of charges.

3. What were the key recommendations of the 244th Law Commission Report (2014)?

It recommended disqualification upon framing of charges for serious offences, stricter punishment for false affidavits, and fast-track courts for cases involving politicians.

4. What is the objective of the Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill, 2025?

The Bill seeks to remove Ministers, including the Prime Minister and Chief Ministers, if they remain in judicial custody for **30 consecutive days** for offences punishable with **five years or more** , while raising concerns regarding the presumption of innocence and potential political misuse.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/z0whPrUugtw](https://www.youtube.com/embed/z0whPrUugtw)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims:

Q.1 Consider the following statements: (2021)

1. In India, there is no law restricting the candidates from contesting in one Lok Sabha election from three constituencies.
2. In the 1991 Lok Sabha Election, Shri Devi Lal contested from three Lok Sabha constituencies.
3. As per the existing rules, if a candidate contests in one Lok Sabha election from many constituencies, his/her party should bear the cost of bye-elections to the constituencies vacated by him/her winning in all the constituencies.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) 1 and 3
- (d) 2 and 3

Ans: (b)

Mains:

Q.1 Discuss the procedures to decide the disputes arising out of the election of a Member of the Parliament or State Legislature under The Representation of the People Act, 1951. What are the grounds on which the election of any returned candidate may be declared void? What remedy is available to the aggrieved party against the decision? Refer to the case laws. **(2022)**

Q.2 It is often said that 'politics' and 'ethics' do not go together. What is your opinion in this regard? Justify your answer with illustrations. **(2013)**

Passport is Not Proof of Citizenship



Source: TH

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) clarified that an **Indian passport is primarily a "travel document" meant to facilitate international transit, not a conclusive "citizenship document,"** sparking debates amidst the ongoing **Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.**

- **Legal Status of a Passport:** While the Passport Manual notes a passport is "strong evidence" of nationality (supported by the *Maneka Gandhi v. Union of India, 1978* judgment), it is **not definitive proof in a citizenship dispute**.
 - Furthermore, under **Section 20 of the Passports Act 1967**, the Union Government can issue passports to **non-citizens in the public interest** (e.g., the **2023 Madras High Court ruling permitting a stateless Sri Lankan refugee to apply for a passport**).
- **Electoral Rolls and Identity Cards:** The Supreme Court in *Lal Babu Hussein v. Electoral Registration Officer (1995)* ruled that inclusion in the **electoral roll grants a presumption of citizenship** that can only be displaced by due legal procedure.
 - However, in May 2026, the Supreme Court in *Association for Democratic Reforms & Ors. v Election Commission of India*, upheld the **constitutional validity of the Election Commission of India (ECI) SIR of electoral rolls** under **Article 324 and Section 21(3) of the Representation of the People Act, 1950**, affirming the ECI's power to conduct limited citizenship inquiries for enrollment.
 - Crucially, the Court drew a strict line between electoral eligibility and citizenship screening, **ruling that voter list deletion does not strip a person of citizenship**, as the ECI determines voting rights rather than formal nationality.
 - To prevent arbitrary disenfranchisement, the Court mandated that suspected cases be forwarded to the **Ministry of Home Affairs for fair adjudication under the Citizenship Act, 1955, prior to elections**.
- **No Universal Proof:** India does not have a single universal citizenship document. Citizenship is determined strictly under the **Citizenship Act, 1955**, and proven through contextual documents establishing birth, parentage, and nationality.
 - In *Sarbananda Sonowal v. Union of India (2005)*, the Supreme Court held that the burden of proving Indian citizenship lies on the person claiming it.
- **Modes of Acquiring Citizenship (Citizenship Act, 1955):** Ordinary citizens who acquire citizenship by birth or descent do not receive a citizenship certificate. A formal citizenship certificate is **only issued when an individual acquires citizenship through registration or naturalisation**.
 - **By Birth (Shift from *Jus Soli* to *Jus Sanguinis*):**
 - Born 26 th January 1950 – 1 st July 1987: Citizen by birth regardless of parents' nationality.
 - Born 1 st July 1987 – 3 rd December 2004: **At least one parent must be an Indian citizen**.
 - Born on or after 3 rd December 2004: **One parent must be an Indian citizen, and the other must not be an illegal migrant**.
 - **By Descent:** Born outside India to Indian parent(s), with mandatory consular registration for births after 3 rd Dec 2004.
 - **By Registration & Naturalisation:** Available to **Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs)**, spouses of citizens, and foreign nationals meeting residency requirements (**generally 12 years**). **India strictly prohibits dual citizenship**.
- **Key Amendments:** The **2003 Amendment** made the law restrictive by barring illegal migrants from citizenship.
 - The **Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA), 2019** reduced residency requirements for specific persecuted minorities (**Hindu, Sikh, Buddhist, Jain, Parsi, and Christian**) from **Pakistan, Bangladesh, and Afghanistan** who entered India on or before **31 st December 2014**.

• WHO IS AN INDIAN CITIZEN?

Under The Citizenship Act, 1955, there are four ways to obtain citizenship:

1. Citizenship by birth: For birthright citizenship, those born in India between 1950 and 1987 are citizens.

- For those born between 1987 and 2003, citizenship is accorded only if either parent is a citizen of India at the time of their birth.

- For those born after 2003, citizenship is accorded if only if either parent is a citizen at the time of their birth and the other is not an illegal immigrant.

2. Citizenship by descent: A person born outside India and who has at least one Indian parent will be granted citizenship, provided that the birth is registered within one year with the Indian consulate in the jurisdiction.

3. Citizenship by registration: This is for persons related to an Indian citizen through marriage or ancestry.



- Citizenship is treated as a legal status arising from facts such as birth, parentage, domicile or naturalisation.

- Documents serve as evidence of those facts. A **passport** is issued because the government is satisfied a person is a citizen. It does not create citizenship.

4. Citizenship by naturalisation:

Naturalisation certificate can be granted to a person who isn't an illegal immigrant and has lived in India for 12 months continuously before applying.

- In the 14 years before the 12-month period, the person must have lived in India for at least 11 years. This is relaxed for some categories.

Waiver clause: If the Centre believes the applicant has rendered distinguished service to science, philosophy, art, literature, world peace or human progress, it may waive all or any of the conditions in the Act. This is how the Dalai Lama or Adnan Sami, the Pakistani singer, got Indian citizenship.

- BY APURVA VISHWANATH

Read more: [Citizenship Amendment Act: Unpacked](#)

Hemis Festival 2026 Begins in Ladakh



Source: AIR

The Hemis Festival 2026 commenced with devotion and enthusiasm at the historic Hemis Monastery in the Leh district of Ladakh.

Hemis Festival

- **About:** Hemis Festival, also known as Hemis Tsechu, is celebrated annually at Hemis Monastery in Ladakh on the 10th day of the Tse-Chu month according to the Tibetan lunar calendar.
 - The origin of the festival is associated with the 8th century and the spiritual legacy of **Guru Padmasambhava**, who is believed to have removed evil forces from Ladakh.
- **Religious Significance:** The festival marks the birth anniversary of Guru Padmasambhava, also known as Guru Rinpoche, who is revered as the Second Buddha in Tibetan Buddhist tradition.
- **Events:** Hemis Monastery, one of the largest Buddhist monasteries of Ladakh, is beautifully decorated for the celebration. The main attraction is the sacred Cham mask dance performed by lamas and monks in the courtyard of Hemis Monastery to the sound of drums, cymbals and longhorns.
- **Ritual Practice:** At the end of the ceremony, a dough sculpture symbolising evil forces is destroyed, and its pieces are thrown in four directions, representing the warding off of evil and the purification of the soul.
- **Local Tradition:** Chhang, a traditional local drink, is served during the festival as part of the cultural celebration.
- **Thangka Display:** Every 12th year, in the Tibetan Year of the Monkey, a large thangka of Guru Padmasambhava, decorated with semi-precious stones and pearls, is displayed.
- **Significance:** Hemis Festival preserves Ladakh's Buddhist heritage, strengthens cultural tourism, promotes brotherhood and offers a blend of spirituality, history, culture and entertainment.

Read more: [Ladakh Hosts Grand Exposition of Holy Buddha Relics](#)

MSME Day 2026-Udyami Bharat



Source: PIB

The Vice President of India will preside over the MSME Day 2026-Udyami Bharat event on 27th June 2026 at Dr Ambedkar International Centre, New Delhi.

- **About:** MSME Day, celebrated annually on 27th June, recognises the role of MSMEs in economic growth, innovation, employment generation, exports and inclusive development, with the 2026 focus on building a resilient, technology-driven and future-ready MSME ecosystem.
- **Key Achievements:** **National Small Industries Corporation (NSIC)** has been upgraded from Schedule 'B' to Schedule 'A' category CPSE, while Ponduru Khadi from Srikakulam district, Andhra Pradesh, has received the [GI tag](#).
- **Multilingual Access:** MSME websites and portals now provide services in 22 Scheduled Indian languages through BHASHINI and NIC, along with AI-enabled voice grievance redressal and document translation facilities.
- **KVIC Product Launches:** KVIC will launch eco-friendly products such as Tukun, Rangtaal, Bela, Vanya and Umang to promote sustainable livelihoods, Khadi, village industries and rural artisans.

Key Initiatives

- **PMEGP 2.0 Portal:** The portal simplify the entire beneficiary lifecycle and integrate with the Jan Samarth Portal for real-time loan processing, sanction and disbursement.
- **SAMADHAAN 2.0 Portal:** It allows reporting and tracking of outstanding dues owed to MSMEs by Central Ministries, Departments, CPSEs and other government agencies.
- **PMS Portal:** The Procurement and Marketing Support Portal is an integrated digital platform that connects Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs) with trade fairs and exhibitions.
- **MSME Global Mart 2.0:** It is a next-generation national digital commerce and trade facilitation platform integrated with the ONDC ecosystem.
- **MSME Testing Portal:** It enables end-to-end digitisation of testing activities by allowing sample booking, payment, application tracking and digital downloading of test reports.
- **MSME Idea Hackathon 6.0:** Under the MSME Champions Scheme, it will support innovators with financial assistance of up to ₹15 lakh per idea through registered Host Institutes.

Read more: [MSMEs- The Backbone of India's Economy](#)